

Sweet redemption for Sabalenka at US Open

After heartbreaking losses in the US Open for the past three years, Aryna Sabalenka won her first title here and the hearts of many fans. More relaxed than ever, she joked about offering the crowd free drinks.

Following her second-round victory, Sabalenka was delighted by a 'mini-me' dressed in a replica of her pink Nike dress, along with a (presumably temporary) tattoo on her arm, next to her stuffed tiger. "It was a really adorable moment," Sabalenka said. "I just looked up, and I saw on the big screen, like, mini-me. It was so cute. It's such a motivation to keep going to inspire the young generation." Later, the champion hugged her little admirer while her family took photos.

The 26-year-old Belarusian will likely never be a crowd favourite when playing an American at Flushing Meadows. But everyone in attendance and those watching on TV were endeared by the tender side of the ferocious power hitter who seized her third Grand Slam title with a suspenseful 7-5, 7-5 final triumph

over Jessica Pegula.

Controlling Sabalenka's volatile emotions has always been key to controlling her high-velocity shots. For the past five months, her boyfriend Georgios Frangulis, a motorsports driver from Brazil, has helped stabilise Sabalenka. When she won the Cincinnati Open three weeks ago, she said, "Thank you to my boyfriend for keeping me happy every day."

Sabalenka recently told *People* magazine, "There was a really tough period where I was really happy to have him by my side, always cheering me up, always making sure that we are doing some fun stuff. But I make sure I kind of forget about tennis and focus on the good things and enjoy my life, even when things are going wrong in my career."

Her season got off to a rousing high with her second straight Australian Open crown. But in March, the suicide of Sabalenka's ex-boyfriend and former NHL player Konstantin Koltsov jolted her. In a social media post, Sabalenka wrote, "While we were no longer together, my heart is broken."

Stomach problems hampered Sabalenka at the French Open during her upset loss to Mirra Andreeva, and a shoulder injury sidelined her from Wimbledon and the Paris Olympics. Adversity proved a blessing in disguise, as she noted during the Cincinnati title run when

she knocked off world No. 1 Iga Swiatek and Pegula. "Things happen for a reason, I guess... I think it was much needed to... spend some time with

myself."

The mid-summer break left Sabalenka fresher than her chief rivals. When she overwhelmed gold medallist Zheng Qinwen 6-1, 6-2 in the US Open quarters, *ESPN* analyst Pam Shriver raved, "Sabalenka is almost as intimidating as Serena



Reward for perseverance: Aryna Sabalenka poses with the US Open trophy after winning the title at Flushing Meadows for the first time ever. REUTERS

[Williams] was. It's almost miraculous how she has recovered from her serving yips in 2022 when she averaged 14 double faults a match." Similarly, Chris Evert noted, "Her [groundstroke] consistency has been a big improvement. Her shot tolerance is now six or seven shots."

But was Sabalenka still as mentally fragile — at the US Open, anyway — as she was physically strong and technically solid? Would the memory of squandering a lead in devastating three-set losses to heavy underdog Leylah Fernandez in 2021, Swiatek in 2022, and Coco Gauff in



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